

Chapter 5

Dinner with the Overtures

“Don’t worry, mi vida.” said Nessa Overture in a raspy whisper as she lay sprawled over her many, many feathery pillows. “I’m not dying or anything.”

She usually had a quiet voice. Not only that, her voice was always a little raspy ever since she became extremely ill as a child. Since then, sickness for her was always a concern to the family. Cody hated seeing his mom in this bad state. After such a crazy morning, coming home to see her sick in bed felt like a universal slap in the face.

“Ma, you never get sick.” Cody said as he gently lay a hefty, white blanket over his mother’s shivering body.

Nessa only paid half-attention to her son’s concerned statement. An old telenovela from the 80’s was playing on a beat up TV that stood on top of her dresser. She hardly ever turned her head from it, but it was also likely because she was too weak to move.

“Your head.” Nessa instantly turned worried once she caught a glimpse of hid bandage. She tried to reach out to place her hand on Cody’s face, but her arms limped down before they could stretch out.

“The bandage makes it look worse. It doesn’t even hurt, but YOU look like you’re in actual pain.”

“Deme un toque.” said Nessa before choking out a dry cough. “Y-yesterday’s rain made it bad.”

Cody poured his mom a glass of water. “You don’t look fine right now.”

Nessa played up an overly hurt expression. “Diay, I don’t need water. I need *that*.” she said, weakly pointing to the master bathroom.

“Painkillers?”

Nessa shook her head. “The special bottle.”

“Tequila?”

“NO.” Her hush voice nearly cracked. “It’s a round bottle. It’s blue.”

When Cody found it, he was shocked at how heavy the thing was. The round, blue bottle looked like a potion from an alchemist’s lab.

“Where’d you get this?”

“My mother. She says it helps people sleep.”

Cody yanked the cork out of the bottle and grimaced after taking a whiff of the medicine. “It looks like poison.”

“In large amounts, it is. Abuelita called it La Botella Raptor. Just pour me a drop.”

Cody carefully tilted the bottle against his mom’s glass. Blue goo trickled out like stale syrup and sunk through the cold water. “What’s this have to do with dinosaurs?”

“Dinosaurs?” Nessa arched an eyebrow. “Oh, no. Mijo, La Botella Raptor means *Kidnapper’s Bottle*.”

Cody nearly spilled it. “Whaat!? Why do you have this?”

“It helps me sleep. Geez.”

The room went quiet.

“Your bandage,” she continued, “Are you late because you got into a fight?”

“Seriously? Do you really think I’d pick a fight with someone?”

“No, but sometimes fights will come your way.”

“Thankfully, there was no fight. I fell, and the reason I’m late is because I had to stop by a friend’s house.”

“Mhm.” Nessa began to doze off.

Cody wasn’t expecting his mom to accept such a blank statement as a legitimate answer. A part of him wanted to talk about Penny. Maybe it was his obsessive side, or perhaps it was his gut telling him to finally open up to his parents. “There’s a girl we know from work and school. She disappeared. And I went to her home to check if she was okay.”

Nessa peeked open one eye in interest. ‘Oh?’

Cody shook his head. “Her dad said she never came home.”

“I’m sure she’s fine. When I was that age, I took off from my folks all the time.”

“What-- eh-- nevermind,” said Cody. “Also, some other friends from the gas station asked if they could come to dinner. They’re worried about me trying to be a hero.”

“Aw, that’s so niiice of them.” said Nessa, already drifting off.

“Nice? Maybe. Distrustful? More likely.” Cody rolled his eyes.

He glanced at his mom and realized she had already fallen asleep. Cody stood there in silence, staring at the blue raptor bottle, amazed at how fast it worked.

“Don’t worry, ma. Rest up.”

Cody gently closed the door and walked away. He turned to his room and nearly crashed into a young man popping out of the laundry room.

“Whoa Codester! Steady on.”

The man had a well-groomed chin strap beard, a backwards trucker hat, and a blue flannel shirt strapped under suspenders. To be honest, the man looked like a college dropout. In reality, he was in his late 40s.

“D-dad? You’re back already?”

“Actually, I’m a holographic projection from the card shop. Whoaaaa.” said Max, pretending to phase his hands past each other.

“Ha *ha*.” Cody rolled his eyes. “So why’re you actually here?”

“I closed the shop early.” Max replied before taking out ingredients for dinner from the fridge. “Your mom’s sick today.”

“Sh’yeah, I noticed. She never gets sick.”

“If you think she’s bad now, you should’ve seen her when she was pregnant with you.” Max went on as he started to swiftly chop some bright, red onions.

“By the way, um, something happened.”

“What’s up?” said Max, still finely chopping the onions.

“Two of my co-workers kind of want to invite themselves over to have dinner here.”

“Come again?” said Max.

“My friends from work wanna eat dinner here tonight because they think I’m gonna make ‘dumb decisions’ tonight.”

Max burst out laughing, nearly slicing his thumb off in the process.

“DAD!”

“Shh. You’ll wake your mom. I’m fine,” said Max. He winked as he recomposed himself.

“Yeah, let ‘em come. Which ones?”

“Ria and Chris.”

Max nodded and grabbed two more onions. “Aw geez, Chris is coming. That guy is a devourer of ground beef. We’re gonna need more meatloaf. Get chopping.”

At dinner, Max left no waiting period to cheerfully probe Ria and Chris. After Olive finished recounting the funny story about her exploding waffle batter, the whole group went into laughter. Cody, Olive, Ria, and Chris were all enjoying themselves at the very story. Nessa was still bedridden, but she probably heard the story also thanks to her incredible hearing.

Once Max finished laughing, he turned to the visitors and cheerfully asked, “So what on earth made you want to eat with us today?”

“Oh... you know...” said Chris, “We barely see Cody outside of school and work. He’s like a total ghost sometimes. It’s nice to actually catch up for once.”

“That, and we’re afraid he’s gonna try and embarrass himself.” Ria butted in.

“Ria!” said Cody.

“How?” Olive leaned forward in her seat.

“How NOTHING.” said Cody.

“Yep, my son’s definitely hiding something,” said Max.

The table slipped into laughter again. Cody joined along to save face, but then he stood up and started to put food on a new plate.

“Hey, I’m gonna go grab a plate for mom.”

“Aww, he’s embarrassed.” Olive giggled. “It’s okay, Cody. Your secret’s safe with us!”

Cody waved his hand in the air to dismiss his sister’s teasing.

“You gotta tell me this secret!” said Olive, turning to Ria.

“It’s nothing big, he just lllllikes a giiiiirl.” Ria continued to tease. “But it was really strange today. She just disappeared. No one knows where she went!”

“Was it on the news?”

“Not yet. Hopefully, the whole disappearance was just a misunderstanding. Cody’s really taking it seriously.”

Olive sighed as she played with her food. “It must be hard for him, honestly. I can’t imagine what it feels like for your crush to go missing.”

“Her family probably feels way worse,” said Ria. “At this point, we’ve done everything we could’ve at this point. It’s better for us to focus on our true calling, monster hunting.”

Max’s food nearly went down the wrong pipe. “Ria, you really gotta stop making these *jokes* about monster hunting.” He said while making a very unconvincing poker face.

“I’ve known for like five years, Mr. Overture.”

Chris butted in. “You don’t have to play dumb, Mr. O. We both know about you and Mrs. Overture being monster hunters.”

Max looked more confused. “Cody told you?”

“No, we figured it out pretty quickly.” Ria butted in.

Max looked more concerned now. “And even though you can’t see the monsters, you actually believe it?”

Ria and Chris simultaneously nodded.

“Fair enough. So, do you kids have any *other* hobbies besides watching my family?” said Max.

“Kung fu.” Ria nonchalantly muttered.

“I do a lot of lucid dreaming.” Said Chris.

“Lucid dreaming— you can control your dreams?” Max genuinely looked impressed.

“Oh yeah! It’s bigger than ever now. Thanks to technology and research, we’re able to access parts of the mind during dreams the human brain was never capable of.”

“Like what? Telepathy.”

“For sure! Scientists are making way with the neurolinks that form during rem cycles. The science books won’t tell you this, but we’re only a couple months away from proving it.”

Olive nearly choked on her meatloaf upon hearing Chris’ bold, yet unsupported claim. “Um. come again, Christopher?”

“Wowhowhow!” Max laughed while pouring himself a glass of juice. “The world keeps on getting bigger by the minute. I remember when monsters were the strangest things I saw.”

“So Mr. Overture,” said Ria, “How long have you been a monster hunter?”

“As much as I’d love to unveil all the details of my family’s secret life, the truth is we gave up that calling a loooong time ago. There hasn’t been a monster in Lumber Land in years, honestly. You kids have nothing to worry about?”

“You really think we’re kids?”

“I don’t ‘think’ that. You ARE children, and you guys have a lot of life ahead. It’s not worth wasting it on chasing invisible creatures.”

Chris chimed in. “We live on a cliffside outside a gas station town. What future is there?”

Max took a bite of food. He needed a moment to chew on the meatloaf AND the question. By the time he swallowed, a response had come to mind. “You can make a difference anywhere, and you don’t need to beat a monster in order to save lives.”

“What makes you think we can save lives?”

“I don’t ‘think’ that, Chris. You can.” said Max, cracking a soft grin.

Suddenly, Olive slammed her hands on the table, nearly hitting her empty plate.

“And yet Cody still turned down his internship with the FCO.”

“Pipsqueek, hush!”

Max picked up a green bean and then playfully flicked it at Olive. He missed, and it accidentally hit Chris the bad luck magnet instead. instead

“Ah!”

“Oops, sorry.”

“FCO?” Ria arched an eyebrow. She then nearly gasped after just a few seconds. “The Federal Cryptid Organization!? Cody had an internship with them?”

“Yup!” Said Olive as she munched on her green bean with a proud smile.

Ria looked like her face was about to split in two. “So all the while Cody’s been denying his destiny by following unrequited love, HE COULD’VE BEEN HELPING OUR NATIONAL HEROES?”

“I’m not sure I’d call any government agency a *national hero*.” said Olive as she swished a cup of apple juice around in a cup as if it were a glass of wine.

“Monsters haven’t been seen in our country for a long time. Whatever classified tasks they do, it doesn’t matter because my son turned their offer down. It was over a year ago, and he still doesn’t like to talk about it. So when he comes back, don’t mention it.”

“I’ll add it to the list,” Olive said before downing the rest of her juice.

Unfortunately, Cody had overheard the entire conversation. He figured the best course of action was to pretend he was talking with his sick mom in her room the whole time. That would avoid any awkward confrontation. The rest of the night was a fine, peaceful dinner. As Ria and Chris were heading out, they both assured Cody that Penny was somewhere safe. They couldn’t have known. However at the same time, there was nothing they could do about it. At the moment, she had her family to worry about her.

Cody went to bed early that night. There was no need for a sleeping aide like the Botella Raptor. He had enough of the real world today. Now, he wanted to get his mind off everything.